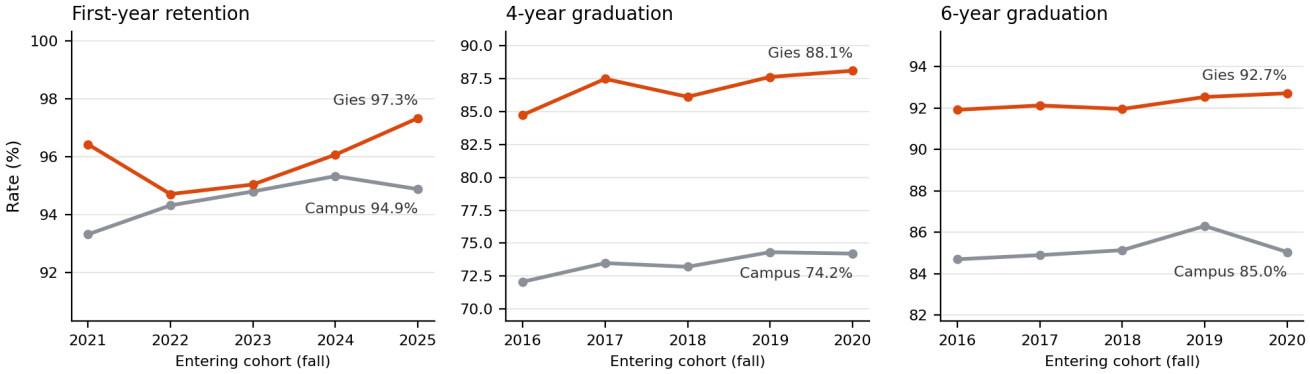
Gies students stay and graduate at the highest rates at Illinois: 92.7% finish within six years, 7.7 points above campus

Findings memo for a program director, November 2026

What the numbers show

- **Gies leads the campus at every stage.** Of the 11 undergraduate entering units, Gies ranks first on first-year retention (97.3% vs 94.9% for campus, fall 2025 entrants), four-year graduation and six-year graduation (fall 2020 entrants). *Source: DAIR.*
- **The biggest advantage is finishing on time, and it is holding steady.** 88.1% of Gies students who started in fall 2020 graduated in four years, vs 74.2% for campus. That 13.9-point gap has stayed between 12.7 and 14.0 points across five entering classes. The first-year retention gap moves around more, from 0.2 to 3.1 points, with no clear direction. *Source: DAIR.*
- **Illinois as a whole graduates about what its first-year retention would predict.** Across 106 public research universities, each extra point of first-year retention goes with about 1.7 extra points of six-year graduation, and retention alone accounts for about 88% of the differences between schools. At 94% retention, Illinois would be expected to graduate 84.5%. It actually graduates 84.9%, just 0.4 points above, which is effectively on the line. *Source: IPEDS, 2023 data files.*



Gies vs all campus by entering class. First-time, full-time, degree-seeking undergraduates; the vertical scales differ by panel. Source: UIUC DAIR, downloaded Nov 2, 2026.

What to keep in mind

- **This shows a pattern, not a cause.** Gies admits a strong entering class, so these numbers do not show how much of the lead comes from the college itself. Likewise, the link between retention and graduation is a comparison of schools. It does not promise that raising retention at one school would raise its graduation rate.
- **The retention and graduation figures describe different students.** Graduation takes six years to measure, so the newest graduation class entered in 2020, while the newest retention class entered in 2025.
- **One year is not a trend.** The 2.5-point retention gap for fall 2025 is wider than in the three years before it, but the gap has swung like this before.

A next question

About 12% of Gies students who started in 2020 needed more than four years or left without a degree. With student-level records, the team could ask who those students are and when they went off track, for example whether first-year course outcomes or a change of major explain most of the delay.

Independent project using public data; not affiliated with the Gies College of Business or DAIR. Public IPEDS rates are rounded, and the 2023 files were the latest NCES release at download.